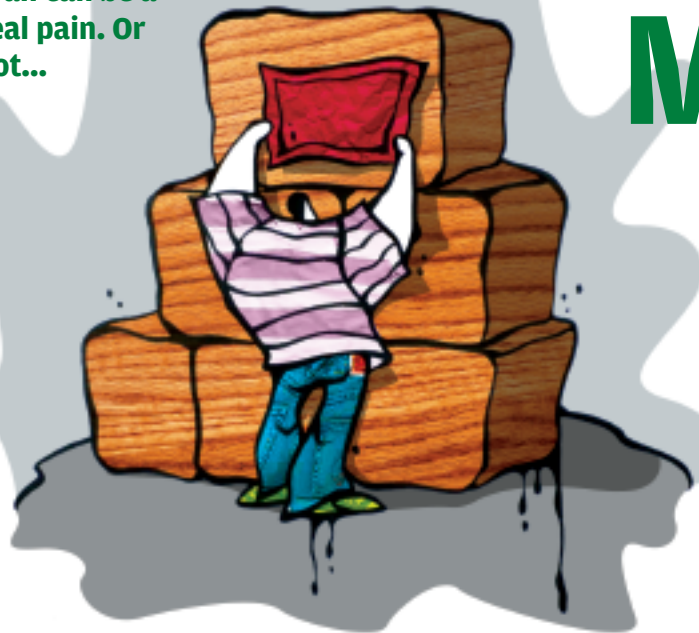




With ever growing media collections, organising it all can be a real pain. Or not...

Can I Play With Madness?



Can I play with madness, The prophet stared at his crystal ball,
Can I play with madness, There's no vision there at all,
Can I play with madness, The prophet looked and he laughed at me,
Can I play with madness, He said you're blind, too blind to see...
—Can I play with madness, Iron Maiden

Robert Sovereign-Smith

With gigabytes (sometimes terabytes) of digital media files on the average PC today, we all have trouble making sense of the clutter. For most of us, sorting ends at segregating video from audio and storing them in different folders. Then one day you're in the mood to listen to that favourite track, and you can't find it.

Those who use Windows Media Player (or iTunes, etc.) can still get away with this by just letting the media player search through the hard drive(s) for media files and add them to the library. Unfortunately, when media files are scattered across the place, some of them inevitably go missing. While installing a large game, copying more media from friends, downloading those HD videos, and so on, you end up seeing the infamous "...running out of disk space on..." error message. So what do you do? Promptly delete folders you *think* you don't need. Then you start seeing errors in your media player, and some of your favourite videos or songs have gone missing... Now although modern media players try to take away the hassle of organising for you, it's not wise to allow them to spoil you. The scenario can be even worse if you end up deleting some important work video, or the background MP3 for your latest presentation...

No Vision There At All

That's for all of us, let's admit it. We have neither the time nor the inclination to sit around searching through our hard drives looking for audio and video files and then sorting them into folders. As usual, we want software to do this for us. The problem is, can software do this satisfactorily? Sadly, the answer is no. Software can help, but it's not going to take over your thinking process just yet.

There is one basic problem with organisation—one user's organised files are another's mess. The best way to illustrate this is to look at the way two different people might want to organise, say, their music collection. One might want to organise the collection in a traditional way—Artist > Album > Song. The second person, however, might prefer Genre > Artist > Album > Song. Some of you might even just like to sort music into, say, moods—Fun Stuff, Head-banging, Mushy Stuff...

Since it's your media collection, you should first sit and decide how you want to sort it all. Remember, even if you sort it all the traditional way, you will probably use a media player to play it all back to you when you want it, so it really doesn't matter that much unless you add and subtract from your collection on a regular basis. For those of you with multiple hard drives, you might want to take the planning a little further and sort media to different hard drives—all audio to D:\ and all video to E:\, or something like that. Some of us like to plan the organisation process with even more gusto—making sure all the videos are on the 7200 rpm SATA hard drive, while it's OK to store music on the IDE drive...

The Prophets

You're in dire need of help. You've probably been looking for software to help you out



MediaMonkey is available as freeware and as a paid version. If you're regularly ripping and burning, and adding to your collection, the paid version is worth it at Rs 800



Sorting Everything

A lot of us have not just media, but everything lying about in utter chaos—documents, installers, Zip files, media, Web pages, flash movies... the works. MediaMonkey will not be able to help you here. However, for Rs 1,600, you can get Universal File Organizer (UFO—Unidentified Filed Objects?) from http://www.mp3musicorganizer.com/about_UniversalFileOrganizer.html, which will do the job for you. The trial version is not crippled, so you can actually use it, but we warn you, it's quite irritating—the trial version only sorts 100 files at a time, and then pauses for 10 seconds, then 20, then 30... you get the picture. If you have thousands of files to sort, using the free version will take quite a while—mainly because after 1,000 files, you have to wait two minutes or more to be able to click continue. The software does its job beautifully though, even sorting the audio just as well as MediaMonkey.



already. For music, there's MediaMonkey—it's famous, and with good reason too. What most people don't know, however, is that by installing a plugin built for Winamp, you can actually get MediaMonkey to sort and play video files as well.

First up, get MediaMonkey from www.mediamonkey.com. Then, find your way to <http://rc4wa.narod.ru/download.html>, and

download the VID4WA plugin. Install MediaMonkey (MM) and unzip the VID4WA plugin to the MM plugins directory—usually C:\Program Files\MediaMonkey\Plugins\.. You can use the free version of MM, but the paid version is a mere Rs 800 and gives you a lot of added functionality: it monitors folders and automatically updates the library, lets you sync with portable devices and provides on-the-fly format conversion (important for an iPod sync), provides CD burning up to 48x, and much more. If organising is all you're interested in, the free version will do just fine.

When you start MM, it asks you to specify folders to search for audio. If you unzipped the VID4WA plugin to the right place, you will also be able to select video file types to search for. If you have no clue where your files are, just let MM search through all your hard drives.

Let's tell you what we did to test MM.

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